

DATE: May 22, 2026

SUBJECT: Analysis of 2-Year Public Enrollment Trends and Federal Grant Allocation

Executive Summary

- Enrollment: First-time, full-time undergraduate enrollment at public two-year colleges declined by 16.65% from 2010 to 2015.
- Baseline Inequities: The current framework heavily favors southern and eastern states. While the proposed policy change improves geographic parity, it cost \$133.3 million.

Data & Methodology

This analysis uses a balanced panel of unrevised IPEDS data, restricted to undergraduate institutions. Institutions that closed or failed to report data during this period are omitted. This survivorship bias suggests the true enrollment contraction is potentially more severe than observed.

2-Year Public College Enrollment Trends

Data confirms a downward trend in student enrollment. Over the six-year window, total first-time, full-time enrollment across public two-year colleges dropped by 16.65% (Figure 1). This persistent decline indicates a long term structural contraction.

Current Federal Grant Distribution (2015-16)

Analysis of the 2015–16 baseline validates state-level funding disparity. Vermont’s per-student federal aid is substantially lower than New York’s (Figure 2). Nationally, the current distribution heavily favors southern and eastern states. (Figure 3) The baseline distribution exhibits high variance, with a 90/10 ratio of 1.63, and a standard deviation of \$373.98.

Simulated Policy Impact

The policy proposal introduces a more equitable distribution (Figure 4). The policy drastically compresses variance, the standard deviation drops to roughly one-third of its original value. The difference between the most favored state and the least favored decreases from \$1,628.80 to \$711.37, and the 90/10 ratio falls to 1.12 (Figure 5). However, an additional expenditure of \$133,304,847.90 to implement the policy.

Conclusion

While the existing geographic inequity can be effectively addressed by the proposed policy, policymakers must weigh this equity against the \$133.3 million cost.¹

¹Figure 6 shows the list of states positively affected and negatively affected by this proposed policy

Appendix: Figures

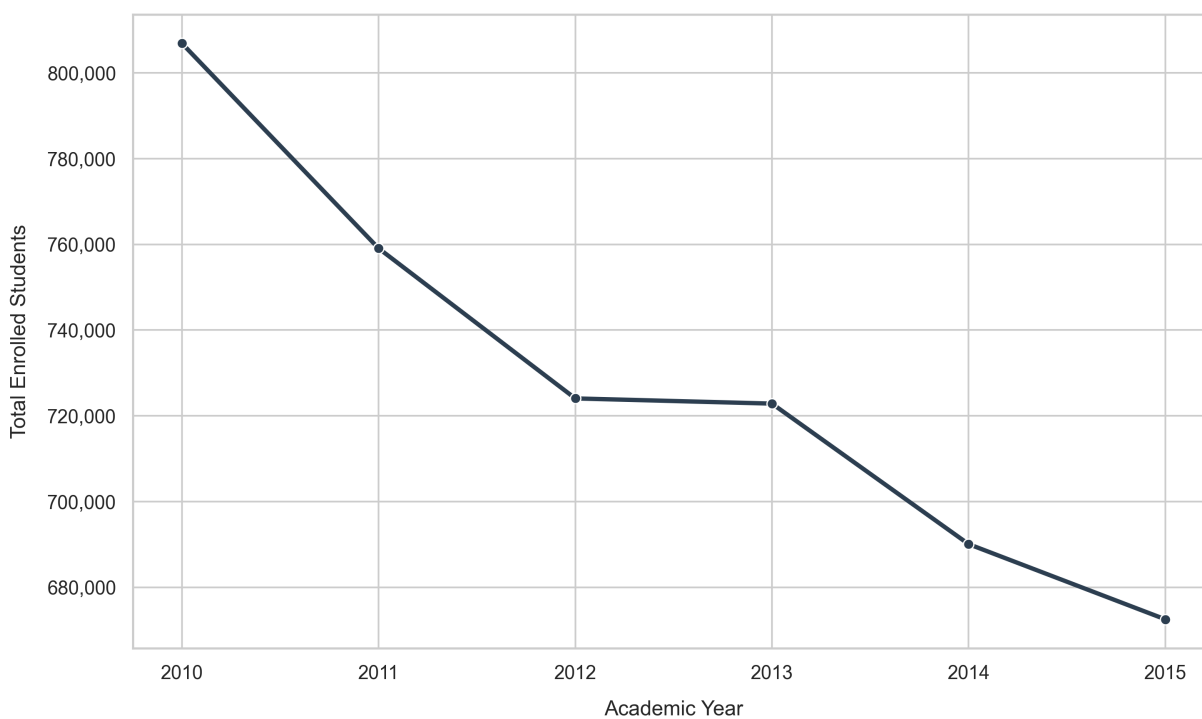


Figure 1: Total First-Time, Full-Time Undergraduate Enrollment Public 2-Year Colleges (2010 - 2015)

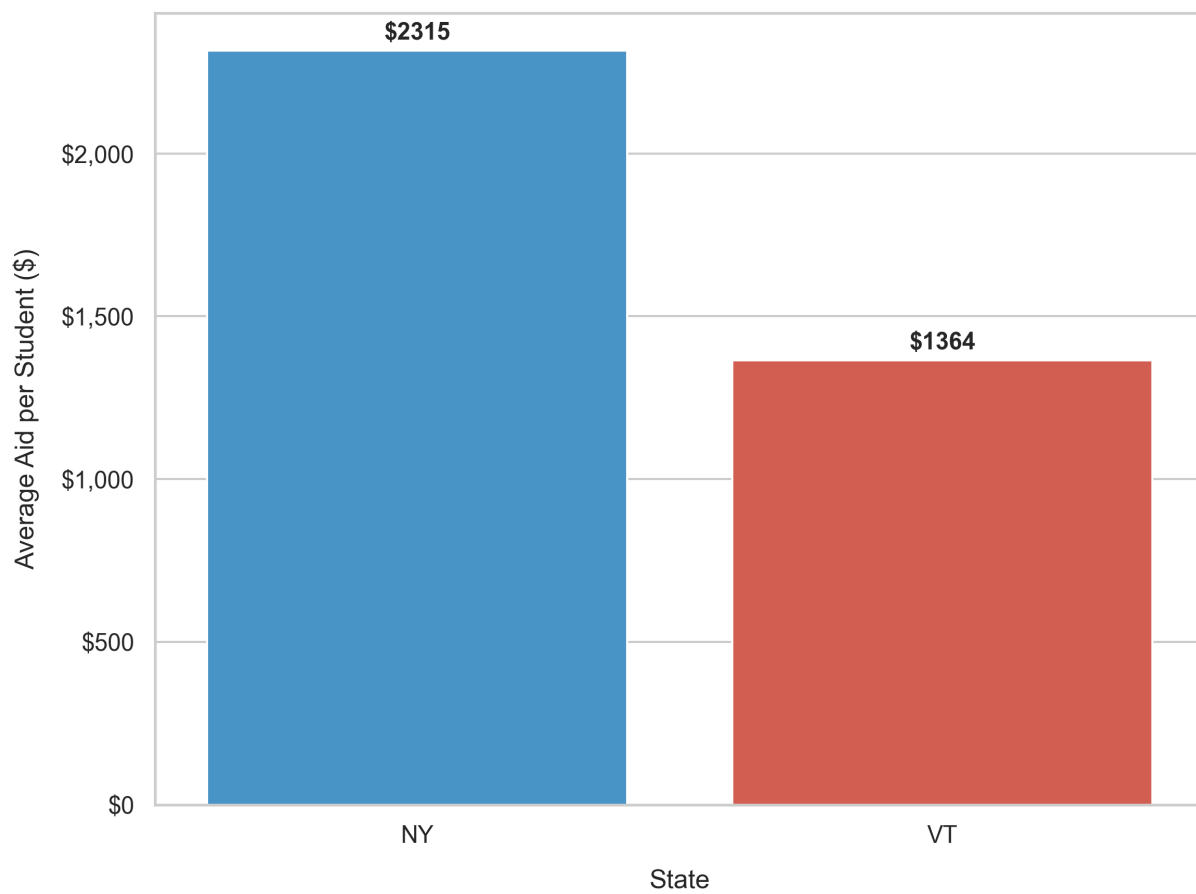


Figure 2: Average Federal Grant Aid per Student York vs. Vermont (2015-16)

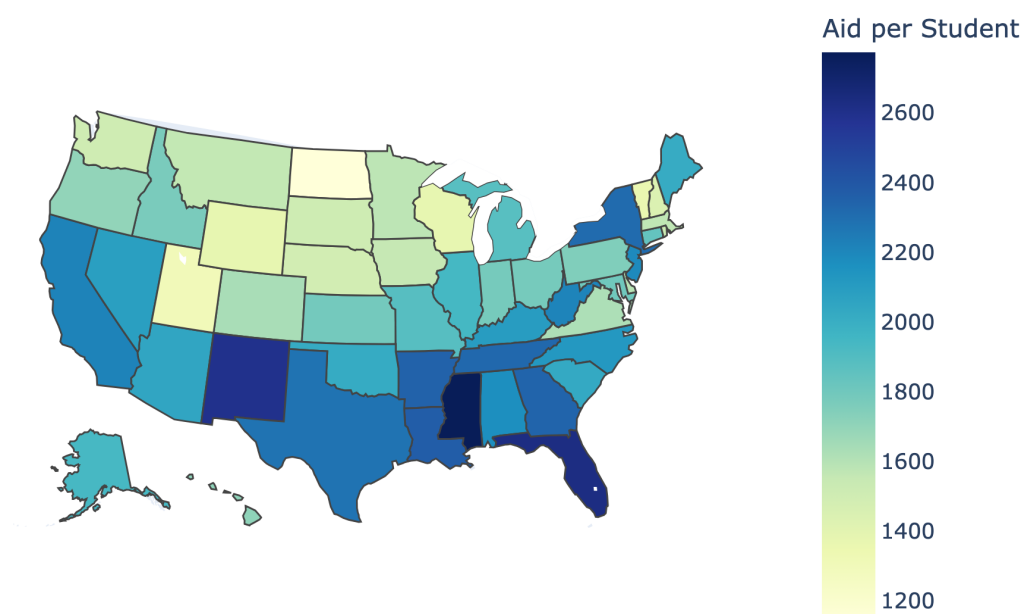


Figure 3: Average Federal Grant Aid per Student by State (2015-16)

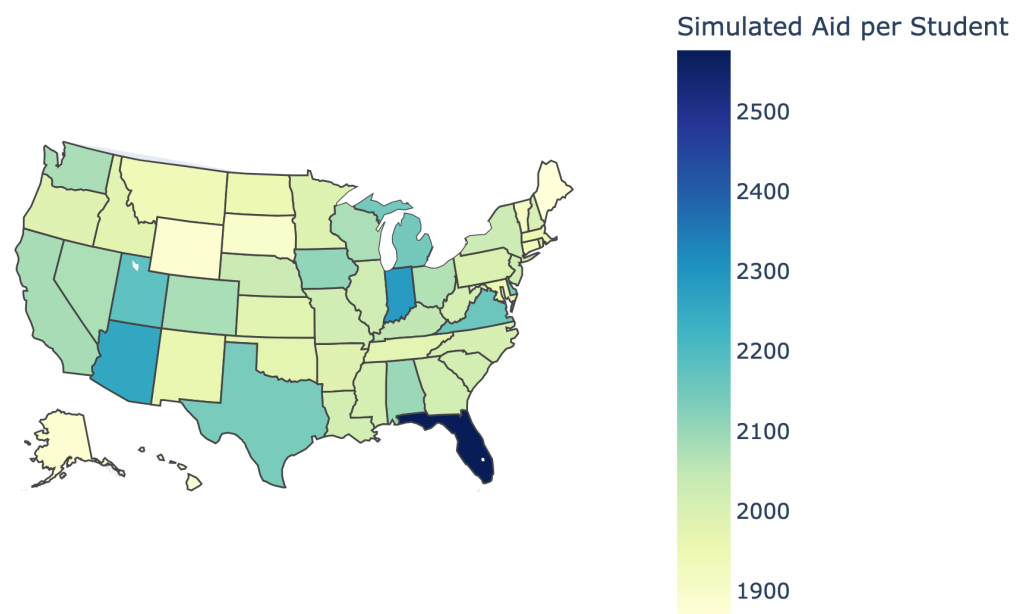


Figure 4: Simulated Federal Grant Aid per Student by State

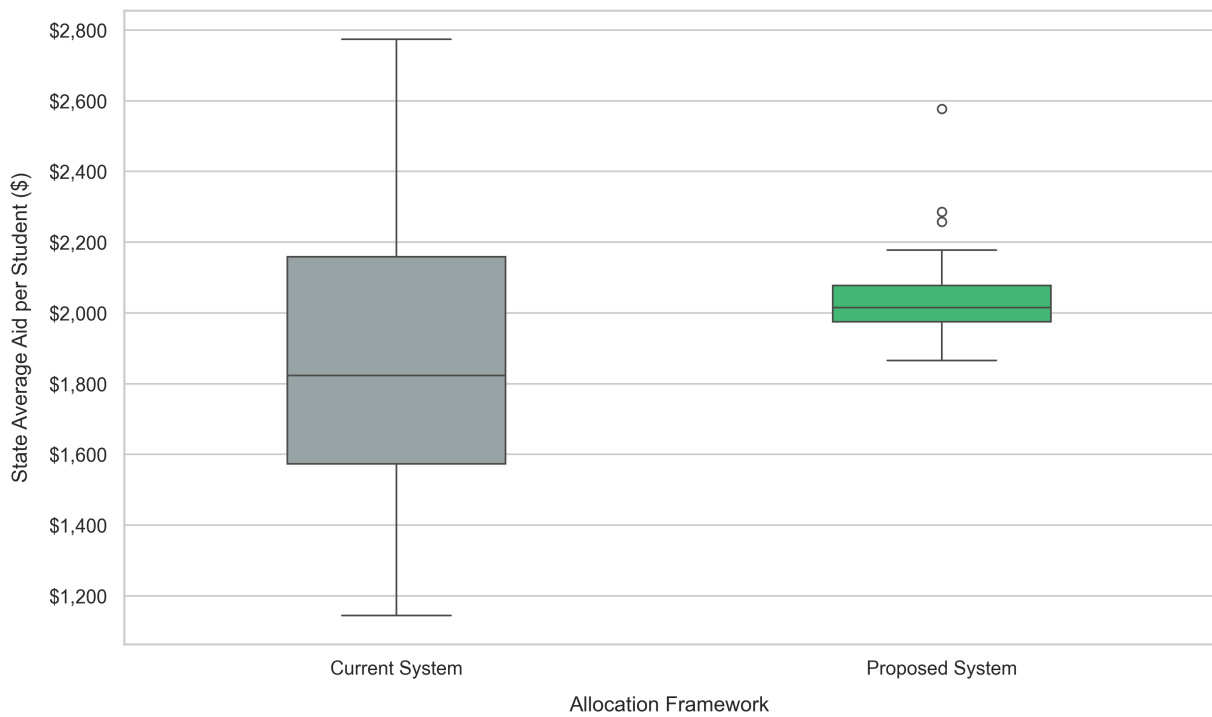


Figure 5: Distribution of State Average Per-Student Aid Policy vs. Proposed Change (2015-16)

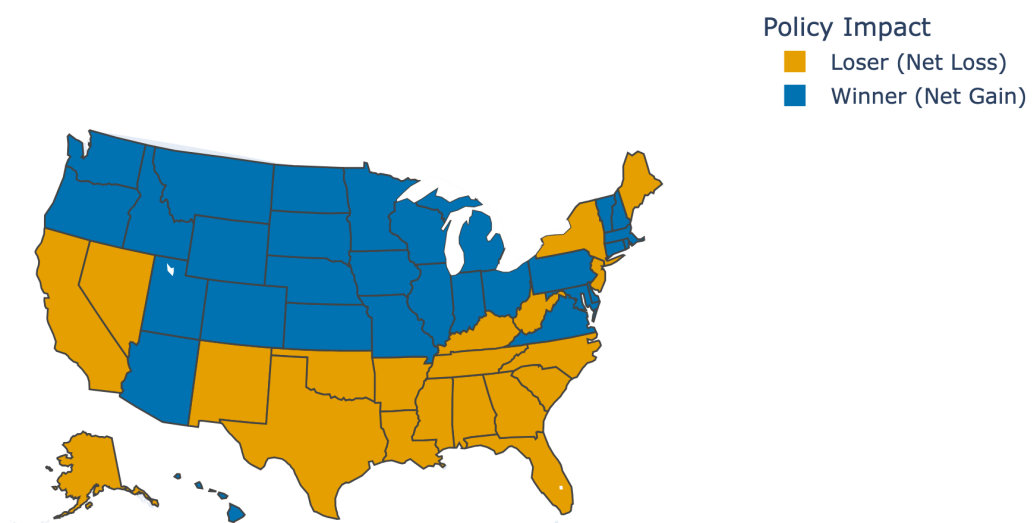


Figure 6: Policy Winners and Losers